# Gadamer

The hermeneutic project of Hans-Georg Gadamer has been one of the most important and influential intellectual trends in post-World War II high culture. What he's attempted to do is find a sort of set of unifying principles which connects the soft sciences and which allows us to get outside the reigning paradigms of historicism and positivism, which he thought threatened the tradition of Western philosophy. Gadamer intends, in his hermeneutic project, to unify the soft sciences with the intention of bringing the person who is adopting this hermeneutic perspective into what's called Wirkungsgeschichtliches Bewusstsein. Wirkungsgeschichtliches Bewusstsein is commonly translated as historically effected consciousness: consciousness of the historical forces shaping understanding. It brings a person towards a kind of comprehension that does not perfectly overlap with univocal reason. Its exercise involves tact, proportion, good judgment and what Aristotle calls phronesis.

Aristotle uses the idea of phronesis, judgment, to refer to those kinds of knowledge which are not entirely univocal, which are not entirely formulaic in their orientation, and yet which are rule governed. The rules that govern the disciplines which entail phronesis are fuzzy rules, are slippery rules, are not the precisely defined rules that we get in things like geometry. What Gadamer is trying to drive us towards is what we might call wisdom rather than knowledge, judgment rather than certainty, a sense of proportion rather than a mathematical certainty. Taste, tact, common sense are all connected together in this idea of historically effected consciousness and this is the sort of thing or this is the end that Gadamer thinks that learning serves or that thinking serves.

Because positivism and historicism tend to undermine this sense of phronesis, this sense of judgment or wisdom, what Gadamer wants to do is go back and reevaluate the theory of knowledge, see where positivism and historicism went wrong, and try and put western philosophy back on the right track. What he's hoping to do is connect individuals, the persons that get this historically effected consciousness, to enlarge their horizon of thought, enlarge their horizon, the domain of their experiences, and then connect their individual horizon up with the overall general collective horizon of the culture as a whole.

The horizon, and he uses that term explicitly, the horizon of a person or of a culture is constructed in language, is constructed within the domain of their symbol system, and as a result what Gadamer offers us is a general way of thinking about the way people think about symbols, the way people think about the world that is not composed of objects. This entails interpretation, and what Gadamer wishes to do is give us a theory of interpretation which allows us to connect the various soft sciences to establish and take seriously the truth of the soft sciences, and then to ask us what sort of knowledge we can get access to independent of methodological formalism.

What he wants to do is break through the formulaic conception of knowledge that comes out of positivism and move on towards a more general encyclopedic conception of knowledge, very much like that of Aristotle. The intellectual sources of Gadamer are very, very wide, and this should not be surprising because most of his intellectual project involves the careful reappropriation of cultural traditions, but altering these

cultural traditions so that they are consistent with the changes in the overall gestalt of knowledge that is a product of historical development. Gadamer is in some ways caught between relativism and absolutism. He likes the idea that knowledge is relative to its historical context and historical time, but he doesn't take it the entire way so that we get the idea that the fact that knowledge is contingent means that it is entirely relative.

At different points in historical time, there are different ways of encyclopedically organizing the cultural traditions that go up to that period of time, and this is an ongoing process. He's something like Aristotle in the following sense. Aristotle holds, for example, that there are rules for constructing tragedies, as described in the *Poetics*, and he agrees that while aesthetic appreciation is in some sense subjective, it is not entirely subjective because there are actually objective rules for things like the construction of tragedies. What Gadamer thinks is that there are something like those objective rules for the interpretation not just of tragedy, but for whole domains of intellectual discourse. And so what he's doing is trying to avoid the relativism and subjectivism that comes from taking history and aesthetics seriously, and at the same time, not diminish the domain of knowledge so that it applies exclusively to the realm of natural science. What he's looking to is to find a way between the two poles, between the rock and the hard place of contemporary thought, and for that reason, he's been extremely influential and very fertile in his suggestions for further research

Aristotle is clearly a fundamental source: his encyclopedic reach, intellectual flexibility in evaluating different kinds of discourse and, most importantly, phronesis. It is the mark of an educated person not to demand more precision from a subject than it can give. We do not allow approximate geometry or usually expect deductive certainty in aesthetics. Rather, we move between domains using different hermeneutic principles and grounds for evaluation.

These grounds for evaluation may change over time, and yet they do allow us a certain degree of knowledge, which is independent of relativism, independent of subjectivity when we apprehend these rules. Aristotle's phronesis, the idea of encyclopedism, and also the sense of proportion that is remarkable in Aristotle is also found in Gadamer. One of the facts about contemporary thinkers is that they, for the most part, tend to take one idea as far in an extreme as they can. If you see Foucault taking postmodernism or Lévi-Strauss taking structuralism, they take one idea and see how far you can extend that idea before it breaks down and before you engender certain contradictions. Gadamer is very opposite to that tendency. He is looking to make a reconciliation between all the competing domains of knowledge so that he can completely absorb the entire cultural tradition of the West and offer us a new sort of encyclopedia, in the sense of a circle of knowledge which moves right around the domains and doesn't feel that its job is the de-legitimation of most of what counts as knowledge.

If you think of what positivists typically do, they set up a Procrustean theory of knowledge and then use it to judge aesthetics or ethics or theology very harshly. Gadamer wants to do the opposite. He wants to inquire into natural science, find its mechanisms of operation, do an interpretation of that both historically and logically, but then also move on to the other domains of knowledge like aesthetics, psychoanalysis, literary criticism, history, and inquire from the inside what the domain is, what its principles of interpretation are, and then find principles which connect the various domains of knowledge so that he can form one encyclopedic stance towards the contemporary world of knowledge. The idea of a hermeneutics is most interesting.

Hermeneutics might be defined as the science of interpretation. Here we have to be very careful about the difference between German and English.

In German, the idea of a science is a Wissenschaft, an organized body of knowledge or statements, whereas in English the domain of knowledge of science is more truncated. It refers almost exclusively to natural science. Usually when we in English talk about science, we're talking about physics or chemistry or biology or something like that. In German, when they talk about science, they use the word Wissenschaft and they just mean an organized body of knowledge, which allows in the domain of physics but also includes things like theology, literary criticism. Their domain of science is larger in the sense that science is a Wissenschaft, an organized body of knowledge. Gadamer wants to offer us a theory of interpretation, a way of thinking about interpretation itself that will move from one domain to another.

Gadamer seeks commonalities applying to a literary critic's interpretation of literature, a psychoanalyst's interpretation of a patient's statements, an actor's interpretation of *Hamlet* or *King Lear*, and Joyce's interpretation and assimilation of the Western tradition in his work. Something holds interpretation together. He searches for a skeleton key: what makes interpretations successful or unsuccessful, desirable or undesirable? This conception of interpretation would draw a circle around the whole domain of knowledge. It derives partly from Schleiermacher. Hermeneutics, the science of interpretation, is not new. Early nineteenth-century German thinkers were particularly concerned with legal and biblical texts.

Schleiermacher's investigations reveal fundamental continuities between interpreting law and interpreting scripture. This suggests extending hermeneutics to all texts. We may then reconsider the idea of text itself: paintings, bridges, architecture and statues are texts in a wider sense. Hermeneutics becomes a skeleton key to the human world rather than merely the natural world. It is an ambitious extension of the hermeneutic tradition. Gadamer also draws on Schopenhauer, Kant and German aesthetics, particularly the conviction that aesthetic apprehension is not wholly relative or subjective. Kant's *Critique of Judgment* and Schopenhauer's conception of the artist's objectivity, in which aesthetic apprehension participates, are important sources.

Gadamer wants to say yes, there is a truth in art. There is something we find out through art that is not formulaic, that is not subject to precisely definable rules and this gives the lie to positivism. This gives the lie to naturalism. This gives the lie to all the claims which want to restrict knowledge to the domain of human understanding of the physical world. In fact, we do understand the physical world as a sort of secondary proposition, but our first and immediate apprehensions are of the human world, the world of signs, the world of symbols, and the world of communication. What he's trying to do is say that art contradicts any positivistic claim.

Reading Shakespeare teaches us something unless we are wholly unresponsive to it. This raises a question for a thinker such as Carnap: how can Shakespeare provide knowledge without a scientific method? Such learning does not follow a hypothetico-deductive procedure of the kind associated with Popper. Denying that Shakespeare teaches anything is implausible. If Shakespeare, Titian or another great artist teaches us, we must ask what is learned and how. It is not acquired through a precisely defined scientific method. Gadamer even doubts whether one unitary method holds science itself together.

His position has affinities with thinkers such as Kuhn, Feyerabend and Rorty, who question the unity of scientific method and emphasize scientific practice and results. What Gadamer is doing is saying, we're going to have to look at other non-methodical kinds of knowledge, account for them, and then he's going to create a big circle around the methodical knowledges and the non-methodical knowledges based upon this idea of hermeneutics and transparency of interpretation. He is clearly appropriating tremendous chunks of the German and Western intellectual tradition, but twisting them and using them to his own purposes. His activity is an example of this historically effected consciousness, which borrows, takes from the past, transforms and accommodates the past, and then uses it for effective historical purposes today. And his effective historical purpose is to give us an example of a new way of thinking about knowledge which goes beyond historicism and positivism. It's a very ambitious undertaking.

Another important source is Dilthey, a late nineteenth-century German thinker concerned with the distinction between natural and human sciences. A related but different distinction comes from Windelband, who distinguishes nomothetic and idiographic approaches to knowledge. And what they say is that one knowledge generates what he calls nomothetic results. Nomothetic means creation of laws. Something like physics, F = ma, there's a nomothetic result.

We see things moving around and then we talk about their force and their acceleration and we come up with F = ma. An alternative kind of thinking is what he calls idiographic, an approach describing particular historical configurations rather than general laws. And the hermeneutic sciences, the soft sciences, are idiographic in this sense. These debates concern the difference between natural-scientific explanation and understanding psychic life or cultural symbolism. The distinction is not simply one between external and internal objects, but also between approaches to knowledge. Verstehen, understanding, is central to the human sciences.

Vernunft is the German word for reason; Verstehen means understanding. Understanding here involves the perspective of a human being, in contrast with allegedly disembodied rationality. On the other hand, the things that are the products of Verstehen, we'd have a hard time explaining to a Martian. The things that are the products of Vernunft, we could explain to any rational being. We could explain arithmetic to a Martian, but it might be very hard to explain, for example, *Oedipus Rex* to a Martian.

One involves viewing things from the perspective of a human being. The other involves disembodied rationality. What Gadamer wants to emphasize is this activity of interpreting things from the perspective of a human being rather than this alleged disembodied rationality. From Husserl, Gadamer borrows two basic ideas. First, the idea that we should have a phenomenological investigation of the domain of knowledge. In other words, we should view it from the eyes of a human being, from the inside, as it appears directly to humans.

And second, that the big targets, the real danger of fragmenting tendencies in the 20th century come from positivism and historicism. Husserl's idea of the life world, approaching knowledge as it appears to a human being, embedded in a concrete historical context, that's the important thing for him. And this all leads up to Gadamer's teacher, and this makes all the difference in the world. Heidegger was Gadamer's

teacher, and Dasein is what Gadamer's hermeneutics is all about. In other words, Heidegger introduces into Western philosophy the idea of Dasein, that being and time, temporality and human existence are inextricably bound up, that language is caught up with being, and that the disclosure of being is bound up with language. There's some sort of an overlap between the two.

Heidegger also develops the hermeneutic circle. His decisive influence here concerns temporality. It is essential to Dasein and therefore has a formative effect on human knowledge. Hermeneutics for Gadamer is the conscious response of human beings confronting, or in some respects constructing, their surrounding world. The human world becomes intelligible within language. He seeks a way to interpret linguistic gestures, taking ‘linguistic’ in its broad sense.

Two consequences of Gadamer’s connection with Heidegger illuminate his project. First, Dasein means that human beings live in temporality. As time moves, we are continually alienated from cultural traditions. Last year’s traditions have changed somewhat, and we have also moved away from them. Goethe’s *Faust* says that what we inherit from our fathers must be acquired anew in order to be possessed. To inherit cultural traditions, we must earn them again ourselves.

Because human beings live in temporality, if they wish to extend the horizon of their understanding so that it is consistent and so that it extends beyond its truncated domain to the horizon of the culture as a whole, what they must do is constantly reinvent the cultural tradition, reabsorb it, reinterpret it, and this process of reinterpretation is what keeps it alive. This process of cultural interpretation is a function of the fact that we live in Dasein and Dasein entails temporality and temporality means that we are constantly being re-alienated from our cultural tradition. I read Plato when I was 20, I read Aristotle when I was 25, but if I want to go back and reclaim Aristotle and Plato, I must read it again and reabsorb Aristotle and Plato based upon the changes in my knowledge, based upon the changes in society as a whole, based upon our new thinking about Aristotle and Plato.

It's not an accident that Gadamer is one of the leading interpreters of both Aristotle and Plato, has done both deep translations and great hermeneutic interpretations, particularly of the ancients. He's not only giving us a general schema by which to go back and reclaim a cultural tradition, which doesn't do violence to non-scientific activities, he's also giving us an example of that reclaiming of a cultural tradition because that's what this book is. It instantiates the methodological preferences that it suggests.

It works on at least two levels, and that's one of the most important and interesting achievements of Gadamer's work. You could say then that hermeneutics is the attempt to overcome this constant alienation from our cultural tradition, and the way we do that is by reabsorbing and reutilizing and reappropriating this tradition, and that process is what holds all of knowledge together. What this seems to entail, and this is one of the criticisms that's been leveled at Gadamer, what this seems to entail is a rebuilding or reconstruction or recreation of Hegelianism. It would seem that at each generation, at each level of historical development, we are called upon to, or each generation is called upon to reinterpret, reabsorb, and reappropriate the previous cultural tradition, and yet it's hard to make Hegelianism a serious philosophical alternative nowadays because of

all the Procrustean teleology, all the metaphysics that comes with it, that's really hard to persuade people with in this day and age.

I think the argument would be something like this, that what Gadamer forces us to or directs us towards is something I would call a soft form of Hegelianism that leaves off the more extreme claims made by Hegel. I would be inclined to say that Gadamer's view is a sort of weak form of the Hegelian progress of the Geist.

The culture progresses not towards some eschaton, some final stage of history where the world ends and we finally reconcile with God. Rather, I think that Gadamer has us progressing not toward some eschaton, but away from our condition of permanent alienation from the culture. In other words, the human condition is such that Dasein requires that we live in temporality. Temporality necessarily continually excludes us and divorces us and alienates us from culture. We progress when we manage to complete the hermeneutic circle and go back to our cultural orientation and undo that alienation. Instead of progress towards something, in Gadamer I think we get progress away from something and that's actually a much smaller, more local claim.

This smaller claim is easier to defend. There is a Hegelian element without Hegel’s full ambition. Gadamer’s greatest work, *Truth and Method*, was published in 1960 as a response to dominant positivism and historicism. Challenging both, it establishes his philosophical hermeneutics. One could almost call it ‘Truth or Method.’ At the time, methodology, particularly scientific methodology, occupied a central place in philosophy. Positivists hoped that establishing natural science’s method beyond question would secure its results and enable a unified science. Gadamer asks whether the choice may instead be between truth and method.

Scientific methods may yield truth, but art shows that knowledge also arises independently of method. The important hermeneutic truths are not formulaic. How do we step outside method and remain within truth? How do we reach that experience, and how should it be understood? There is a parallel with the later Wittgenstein’s *Philosophical Investigations*: the language-game of natural science is one among many, without an automatically privileged place. Gadamer does not reject science. It has internal rules and works within its domain. But positivists claiming that all knowledge is physics exceed what can be supported. Aesthetic truth is his great counterexample.

There are three sections to *Truth and Method*. The first is devoted to art, and the key thing for art and aesthetics as far as Gadamer is concerned is that this discloses a human truth which is undeniable. He says, in good faith, even a positivist can't tell you you don't learn things from Shakespeare, even a positivist can't have the nerve to tell you that art doesn't disclose any information about the human world to you. The problem is that it doesn't disclose information, it doesn't let you know things on the basis of some formula. It isn't necessarily univocal. Here's where he brings in Kant and Schopenhauer on the objectivity of aesthetics, and he also emphasizes the idea that play and recreation is connected with the idea of representation, and all of these ideas are subsumed under the idea of a language game.

Art is ludic, involving games and play. Gadamer brings play, presentation and representation together. This can be compared with overlapping local language-games sharing similarities without a single ultimate standard adjudicating all differences. It is an inclusive conception of knowledge, like Aristotle’s. Aesthetic activity apprehends and

appropriates cultural traditions such as tragedy and literature. The idea of transparency offers a way to explain its success. How do we recognize a good interpretation? Psychoanalysts, literary critics, theatrical directors and actors all interpret texts or undertake interpretive activities, though in different ways.

We have encountered good and bad interpretations. How do we distinguish them, and how do we move between interpretive genres? An actor and a director both interpret *Hamlet*. What holds these activities together is described here as transparency of apprehension. An interpretation is adequate or successful insofar as we no longer see or hear the interpreter obstructing the work. Consider Vladimir Horowitz, the great Romantic pianist whose repertoire includes Schubert and Schumann. His playing is transparent: one does not simply hear Horowitz displaying himself.

One hears Beethoven or Schubert. Compare a fine pianist with a beginner making mistakes and producing sour notes. The latter can be irritating because one does not clearly hear Beethoven or Schubert. It is a weak interpretation.

What stands out is the struggling piano student rather than the music. The example extends to theatre. Laurence Olivier offers a good interpretation of *Hamlet* when we hear Hamlet rather than merely notice Olivier. When the performer becomes transparent to the represented character, we encounter the person on stage instead of merely the actor’s effort.

A director must decide blocking, lighting, timing, delivery and the organization of theatrical space. A successful interpretation makes us see *Hamlet* rather than merely the director, for example Joseph Papp. Insofar as the artist or interpreter dominates, the interpretation is opaque. Insofar as the represented thing appears rather than the representer, the interpretation is transparent. This provides a criterion for good or desirable interpretation.

Look at the advantages. Common sensically, there's a great deal of truth in this. When we listen to the beginning piano student, what we hear are their terrible, egregious mistakes and we do not like that interpretation of Beethoven. On the other hand, when we hear the accomplished pianist, the reason we may like the interpretation is because what we are hearing is the music. What we like about certain interpretations of *Hamlet* is that we get to see the play. It discloses the play to us rather than the intention of the actor or the director.

Transparency can extend beyond art, including literary and plastic arts, towards psychoanalysis. A good analyst’s interpretation of an analysand’s speech allows that person’s thoughts to be heard, rather than imposing a Procrustean formulation exposing the analyst’s theory. Psychoanalysis and literary criticism both involve rule-governed interpretation of signs and symbols rather than merely natural objects.

They do so on the basis of schools of thought, and we know we have a good interpretation within these schools of thought when we get transparency, when we see the thing being interpreted. This is a very deep thought, and he has found a sort of bones or a sort of vertebrae, a sort of skeleton to interpretation which had been previously thought invertebrate. What he's doing is finding something between the absolute univocal certainty of, say, arithmetic, and the infinite variety of mere questions of taste, showing that there are certain what I would call slippery or fuzzy rules which govern this sort of discourse, which govern all the soft sciences, and that doesn't make

them less rule-oriented and doesn't make them less legitimate knowledge for that purpose. Think of the differences when we get to historicism. In other words, if scientism is the idea or positivism is the idea that knowledge is exclusively truncated and limited to the domain of physics, historicism allows that there might be an elaborate and very extensive domain of human knowledge, but that it's entirely relative. In other words, this is the flip side of the coin.

One goes for certainty, but only allows certainty positivism within a domain of a very limited set of discourse. The other alternative goes for skepticism, doesn't go for certainty, but it includes all of human activity. Historicism, here I'm thinking of somebody like Dilthey or most of the late 19th century German thinkers are wrapped up in the idea of historical change and the incommensurability of historical projects. What Hermeneutics wishes to do, what Gadamer wishes to do is to call that into question, saying, look, think about the interpretation of Oedipus back in the time of the ancient Greeks and think of the interpretation of Oedipus now. Although there are many changes between us and then, and doubtless our interpretation of Oedipus may have to deal with a great many other texts that have come to influence us since. For example, our staging of Oedipus may have to have some sort of connection with Freud.

We may have to emphasize the Oedipal, literally, the sexual feelings for the mother in our interpretation of Freud or our interpretation of Oedipus that may not have been entirely necessary 2,500 years ago. But, nonetheless, there still are certain facts about the Oedipus drama that must come through any interpretation if it is to be a successful or satisfactory or transparent interpretation. In other words, our interpretation nowadays of Oedipus in order to be successful and transparent and satisfactory may emphasize the Oedipal drama and the sexual desire for the mother and the hatred of the father and it may also include a great many other things that have been added to our culture that inform and deepen and enrichen the Oedipus drama.

But, there will be some sort of necessary continuity between a successful interpretation of Oedipus today and a successful interpretation of Oedipus 2,500 years ago because it is alleged to be disclosing some ultimate fact about human life. You cannot ignore that fact if we do, either then or now, we have an opaque interpretation, a bad interpretation. And it seems, then, that he has found a sort of skeleton key, not just to the interpretation of works of art, but to the interpretation of the whole human domain.

And it allows for historical change, it allows for enrichment, increasing depth, and increasing complexity. And yet, within this complexity, he finds a string which leads us through the labyrinth and the string which leads us through is this transparency of hermeneutic interpretation. This is a very deep project and it's a very impressive piece of work. The result that he wishes to bring us to, this historically effected consciousness, will be a hermeneutics guided by language. And what we will do if we adopt this perspective is move, make an ontological shift in our concerns from nature to man and from object to subject. This corresponds to the move from vernunft to verstehen, from reason to understanding.

The shift is from looking at the world externally to contemplating it from within. It can be illustrated through hard and soft rules. A relatively precise grammatical rule is the ordinary requirement of a finite verb in a complete independent English clause.

Compare the equally real but less exact requirement that a good essay should be divided into paragraphs. There are standards for paragraphing, but these are less precise than grammatical rules for complete clauses. We recognize the requirement without possessing a formula for every case.

It would be mistaken to say that an imprecise rule is no rule. An essay without paragraphs can be judged deficient. Yet stating exactly where and how to divide it, with the precision expected of grammar or arithmetic, is difficult. The rule is soft, flexible and dependent on judgment.

You might want to say then that hermeneutics, this hermeneutics that's guided by language is a science of soft rules. Which says, don't throw the baby out with the bathwater. All rules aren't hard. That's the big mistake of positivism. Don't think that soft rules aren't really a kind of knowledge. That's the mistake of historicism.

That just means that at night all cows are black. What he's trying to give us is this conception of soft rules and to make us a little more sophisticated about our own language. One of the results of Wirkungsgeschichtliches Bewusstsein of Gadamer's particular hermeneutic stance towards the world is that it makes you a little bit dicey, a little bit suspicious about your own language and about your own concepts. It tells you, look, everybody else has been biased, influenced by their cultural traditions. You must be too. Although you can't avoid the burden or the charge of absorbing your cultural traditions, you must be a little suspicious, a little thoughtful about the way in which you do that.

And the way in which he wants to do it is by going back and looking at the way in which we acquire this historical horizon, the way in which we appropriate these historical traditions, and what we're going to do is use language to understand the fact that language itself is historically conditioned and that this historical conditioning distorts interpretation and that that's not a problem, that's just the human condition, that's part of Dasein. You acknowledge for that, you make the best allowances that you can, and then you go back to the question. In other words, what emerges is a sort of dialectical relationship between a text or the whole domain of human culture. We go into that with certain expectations, and eventually we find these expectations thwarted. When our expectations are thwarted, we renew our interpretation, we come back, we create a new set of expectations, and we carry those around and examine the text of the world or the text of culture. It gets thwarted eventually, we come back and we renew our interpretation.

This is the hermeneutic circle, the logic of question and answer, and it continues indefinitely. We interrogate culture and receive answers. A new or surprising answer requires us to reformulate questions and background knowledge, then resume the inquiry. The circle is not vicious. It describes the human condition when the realm of symbols, rather than nature alone, becomes our primary concern.

What, in the last part of *Truth and Method*, what Gadamer does, which is a very impressive idea, is not only does he show us that we have reason to be a little bit suspicious of our own cultural traditions, a little bit suspicious of our own linguistic inheritances, then the thing that he does is he gives us a history of the concept of language itself. He says, fine, I'm going to appropriate the Western cultural tradition. He goes back to Plato, goes back to Aristotle, works on their concept of the logos, and

then writes us a small history of the concept of the logos, of language, that starts with the Greeks, moves through Thomas Aquinas and scholasticism, comes right up to Hans Georg Gadamer, and he says this is where it goes to.

What an incredible intellectual tour de force, and it's the opposite of the snake eating its own tail, it's the snake kind of vomiting itself up. It's the creation of something, not quite out of nothing, but out of historical duration, out of Dasein. You might want to say then, and this is an interesting way, a Heideggerian way of reading hermeneutics, is that his problem with science is that, like Heidegger, Gadamer believes that science discloses beings, with a small B and an S at the end, whereas hermeneutics discloses being, capital B, with no S at the end, because that's the realm of the truly human.

When you have completely absorbed your entire cultural tradition, that is the realm of Dasein, that is the realm of being. Language and being perfectly overlap then, so we never quite get to that point, but every one of us, at any given moment in historical time, we're living somewhere, we're in Dasein, and our job is to make the most of our horizon by reconnecting ourselves to that historical horizon of our culture, and that means the constant, ongoing process of reinterpretation. Very, very deep interpretation of what knowledge is and how knowledge works. Language turns out to be the horizon of this hermeneutic ontology, and it turns out that Dasein is disclosed to us, the kind of being characteristic of human beings comes to us when we absorb human culture, when we perform this hermeneutic activity, and what's very important for us here is that these slippery rules have to be appreciated as an important contribution to the theory of knowledge.

In other words, I would say Wittgenstein and Gadamer are two figures, rough contemporaries, Gadamer is a little younger, who are both concerned with showing that if we don't get perfectly rule-governed knowledge, in the sense that grammar is rule-governed, it does not follow then that we have gibberish or absolute relativism. What you can still have are degrees of certainty.

Aristotle’s warning returns: do not demand more certainty than a discipline can give. Gadamer offers flexibility, encyclopedism and a willingness to seek commonalities where none were recognized. His criticism of formalism and method corrects the positivist paradigm of a unified natural science, suggesting a more achievable unity through language-based hermeneutics. He aims at Bildung, cultivation. Richard Rorty draws substantially on this conception for his account of education and knowledge.

In many respects, the pragmatic flexibility of Gadamer has many similarities to the tradition of American pragmatism. It's not hard to see why flexible Gadamer would be very attractive to flexible Rorty, because Rorty doesn't want to throw the baby out with the bathwater and get gibberish, but he insists that this positivist program of reducing all knowledge to physics just doesn't work. Much of Rorty's conception, postmodern conceptions of language and thought and the aims of education are borrowed from Gadamer's idea of Bildung, from this Wirkungsgeschichtliches Bewusstsein. A second influence will be this idea of clarity. This has been very important as a way of holding together the idea of interpretation. The director and the actor and the psychoanalyst and the literary critic are all pursuing the same goal in different genres.

This connects interpretive activities in a compelling way. Gadamer’s greatest influence may lie in historical aesthetics. Another, less often mentioned connection concerns

communitarianism, an alternative to the rights-based political philosophy associated with Rawls, Dworkin and other mainstream legal thinkers. Thinkers such as Galston and Sandel emphasize the historical embeddedness of communities, the common good and the appropriation of consensually accepted historical traditions.

What the communitarians are doing is trying to drive us back to the reappropriation of our cultural traditions as a way of avoiding the sort of anomie and atomism of rights-based and rationalism of rights-based political theory. For that reason, much of the influence, or the kind of inspiration for communitarian political theorizing has been derived from this hermeneutic tradition, because what the communitarians are going to say is that there are soft rules governing our obligations to political communities. We have rejected these rules or ignored these rules because we have been under the spell of positivism, or under scientistic thinking, which prevents us from accepting any but the hard, fast grammatical type rules. In political philosophy, particularly in this communitarian tendency, Gadamer figures very heavily. In historical aesthetics, Gadamer is of the greatest influence. And most importantly, Gadamer has been important because he offers us a new way out of the labyrinth of modernity or post-modernity, which brings together a great variety of relatively disparate influences and intellectual activities under the aegis of one unifying idea, clarity of interpretation.